

U N I T 4 · L E S S O N 3

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

20–25 min · Week 24 · Permanent Post

O B J E C T I V E	Students learn the four-step Pause Practice for charitable interpretation, and articulate that we usually give the benefit of the doubt to people we like — the practice begins where the kind story runs out.
C A S E L F O C U S	Social Awareness · charitable interpretation; Self-Management: pausing reactivity
V O C A B U L A R Y	benefit of the doubt · pause · charitable · kind story · first thought · choose
M A T E R I A L S	Sammy puppet · The Pause Practice anchor chart · scenario cards (Unit 4 Lesson 3 cards)

ILLINOIS SEL ALIGNMENT GRADES K-2 · EARLY ELEMENTARY

Goal 2 — Social Awareness & Interpersonal Skills

2A.1a Recognize that others may experience situations differently from oneself.

2A.1b Use listening skills to identify the feelings and perspectives of others.

Aligned to the Illinois Social/Emotional Learning Standards (ISBE).

O P E N I N G R E V I E W · 1 – 2 M I N

Show the Mercy chart. "Last lesson: mercy is a choice. Today: a tool we use BEFORE we even know if mercy is needed. We use it when something happens and we don't know WHY."

SAMMY · KIND COACH VOICE

"Someone bumped into me in the hall. I didn't know if they did it on purpose. My brain said 'mean!' But — wait — there is another way to see this."

► DIRECT INSTRUCTION

*Scripted teaching sequence · 5 STEPS · read aloud or in your own words***01 Step 1 · Something Happens**

3 MIN

Begin: "Something ambiguous happens. You do not know WHY someone did what they did. Did they mean to? Did they not see? Were they having a hard day? You do not know. Yet."

02 Step 2 · Notice Your First Thought

4 MIN

Continue: "Your brain has a FIRST thought. 'They did it on purpose!' 'They are mean!' NOTICE the thought. Do NOT act on it yet. Just notice."

03 Step 3 · Pause

4 MIN

The crucial step: "PAUSE. Ask: 'What is another way to see this — a kind one?' Maybe they did not see you. Maybe they were rushing to help someone. Maybe they were having a hard day. A KIND story might be true."

04 Step 4 · Act on the Kind Story

5 MIN

The action: "Unless you KNOW for sure — act on the KIND story. 'They probably did not see me.' 'They are probably having a hard day.' You can be wrong about this. You usually won't be."

05 Where the Kind Story Runs Out

5 MIN

Land the deepest point: "Notice WHO you give the kind story to. Probably people you LIKE. The real practice begins where your kind story RUNS OUT — with people you don't like, people who annoy you, people who have hurt you before. THAT is the practice."

Sammy: *"I give the kind story to people I like. The practice is giving it to people I don't."*

KINDERGARTEN

GRADES 1 – 2

Stay with three steps: "Something happens. Pause. Choose the kind story." The four-step pause is too granular for K. The kindness is the lesson.

Engage all four steps with practice scenarios. Discuss: who is HARD to give the kind story to? What happens when we practise anyway?

EXIT TICKET

"Pause. Choose the kind story." — say it together. Sammy bows."

Sammy: thumbs-up to every hand. No commentary. Sammy validates participation, not content.

TEACHER REFLECTION

Which students could not generate a kind alternative explanation? Which generated kind stories quickly? Which only gave kind stories to friends? Each tells you something different.

SAFETY CHECK

POST-LESSON CLOSE-OUT · No specific risk. Standard close-out.

Did anything arise today requiring counselor follow-up? ☐ No ☐ Yes — contact counselor today

FAMILY CONNECTION

A Note Home

Today we learned the Pause Practice: when something feels unkind, PAUSE and ask: "Is there another way to see this?" At home, model audibly: "I was upset, but then I thought — maybe they were..." Modelling makes the pause learnable.

A N C H O R C H A R T · U N I T 4 · L E S S O N 3

Print this page · Laminate for durability · Post in classroom · Keep posted all year

ANCHOR CHART · CLASSROOM DISPLAY — PRINT ON CARDSTOCK OR 11×17, POST AS THE LESSON INDICATES

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE · BOOK 1 · THE FOUNDATION (K-2)

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

GRACE

The Pause Practice

1

Something Happens

You do not know WHY someone did it. Did they mean to? Did they not see?
You do not know — yet.

2

Notice Your First Thought

"They did it on purpose!" Notice the thought — do NOT act on it yet.

3

Pause

Ask: "What is another way to see this — a kind one?" A kind story might be true.

4

Act on the Kind Story

Unless you KNOW for sure — act on the kind story. You can be wrong. You usually won't be.

The practice begins where the kind story runs out.

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UNIT 4 · LESSON 3

PERMANENT POST

The Pause Practice

Choosing the Kind Story

*When something happens and you're not sure why —
use the Pause Practice before you react.*

1



SOMETHING HAPPENS

You are not sure why someone did what they did.

2



NOTICE YOUR FIRST THOUGHT

What did your brain say? Notice it. Do not act on it yet.

3



PAUSE

Ask: "What is another way to see this — a kind one?"

4



ACT ON THE KIND STORY

Unless you know for sure, choose the kind story.

NOTICE WHERE YOUR KIND STORY RUNS OUT

*We give the kind story to people we like.
That's where the real practice begins.*

TEACHER NOTE

Post BEFORE the scenario practice. Keep permanently. The four steps should become automatic by end of Unit 4.

SCENARIO CARDS · UNIT 4 · LESSON 3

Print · Cut vertically · Laminate · Reuse year after year

UNIT 4 · GRACE & GENEROSITY · APR-JUN

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

CUT VERTICALLY · LAMINATE · REUSE

SCENARIO · 4-C

Giving the Benefit of the Doubt

THE SITUATION

Sofia texted her friend group that she couldn't come to a birthday party. Nobody wrote back. Her first thought was, "They're ignoring me on purpose and they're mad."

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- ▶ Was that the most likely reason nobody wrote back?
- ▶ What are some other possible explanations?
- ▶ What would the PAUSE PRACTICE say to do next?

SCENARIO · 4-D

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THE SITUATION

Marcus walked past his classmate Deja without saying anything. Deja's first thought was, "He's still mad at me about something."

DISCUSSION QUESTIONS

- ▶ What is a kinder explanation for why Marcus didn't say hi?
- ▶ What does Step 3 of the Pause Practice say to ask?
- ▶ Practice saying the charitable interpretation out loud.

D R A W I N G E X A M P L E · U N I T 4 · L E S S O N
3

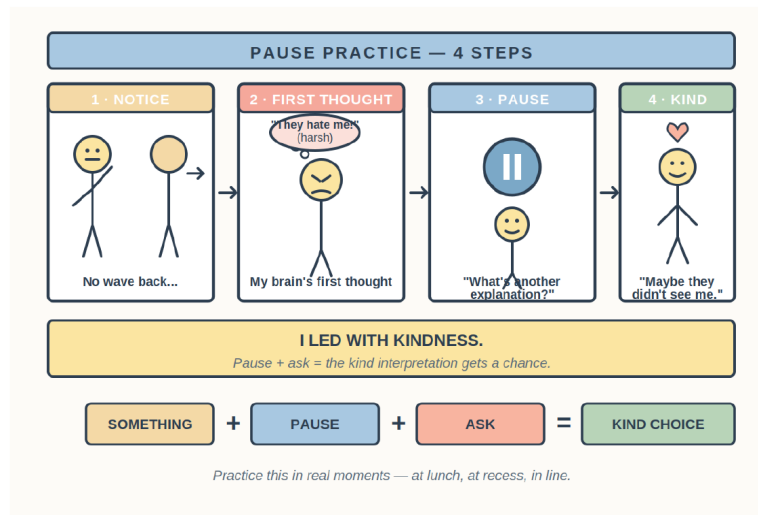
Visual reference for the drawing activity

DRAWING EXAMPLES · TEACHER REFERENCE

UNIT 4 · LESSON 3 · DRAWING EXAMPLE 14

PAUSE PRACTICE COMIC

Students draw a 4-panel comic showing the Pause Practice steps in action.



HOW TO DRAW IT

- ▶ **Panel 1 — SOMETHING HAPPENS.** Draw the confusing moment (someone didn't wave back, walked past without smiling).
- ▶ **Panel 2 — FIRST THOUGHT.** Show a thought bubble with the harsh / negative interpretation. Label: "My brain's first thought."
- ▶ **Panel 3 — PAUSE + ASK.** Show the character pressing a pause button. Speech bubble: "What's another explanation?"
- ▶ **Panel 4 — KIND CHOICE.** Show the character choosing the generous assumption. Label: "I led with kindness."

TEACHER NOTE

Model the comic strip on the board first using a real classroom example (names changed). Students work in pairs to come up with their own situation.

ARCHITECTURE OF GRACE

This is a free preview.

Sample Lesson · Book 1 · The Foundation (K–2)

The complete, classroom-ready curriculum — with anchor charts, worksheets, Illinois SEL alignment, and scripted Direct Instruction — is part of the Architecture of Grace district library. Educators can license the full set; families can find materials in the family store.

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